

DOES THIS SECTION
EVEN NEED AN
INTRODUCTION?
FROM COMPUTERS
TO MOBILES, AND
HEADPHONES TO
GPUS, IT'S ALL
HERE...

UP-DROID

THIS MONTH IN TECH:

We learn about the origins of spreadsheets and then Level-Up with alternatives to popular Android apps. While we're still on Android, we take a look at how to get the new Android P features on older versions.



Prepare for big VR news at F8 this year

This year's F8 developer conference might see the launch of a standalone Oculus Go headset that was shown earlier last year, along with the "biggest VR news from Facebook till date". <http://dgit.in/OCVRF8>

WHAT'S NEW

Alexa gets brief mode

As if almost on cue after Alexa scared people the world over with her creepy, random laughing, Amazon seems to have introduced a 'Brief mode' in Alexa that makes the assistant talk less. To be accurate, it changes verbal responses to commands with a 'chime' sound.

Reddit users spotted the feature first. A specific user reported that after asking Alexa to shut off the lights, after responding with a confirmation, it informed that this would be the last time that a verbal confirmation would be provided. While the feature is limited so far, it could be combined with a do-not-disturb mode to set specific times,



e.g from midnight to your morning alarm, as 'brief mode' time. It could also work in conjunction with other apps to make Alexa talk less depending on the current context.

<http://dgit.in/AlexaBrief>

Japanese supercomputer for nuclear fusion

With a new Cray XC50, Japan will be deploying the world's most powerful supercomputer dedicated to advanced nuclear fusion research in 2018. To be installed in the National Institutes for Quantum and Radiological Science (QST), the system will also be put to use to serve the cause of ITER, the multinational



fusion project that is planned to come online in 2035.

As a resource, the system will be available to more than 1,000 European and Japanese researchers. While it will be the

fastest in its own domain of fusion research and plasma physics, it will merely break into the top 30 among all supercomputers. It might prove to be crucial in making fusion energy a reality

as soon as within the next 10 years, which will lead to seemingly limitless power for humanity for millions of years.

<http://dgit.in/JapSup>



Xbox controllers on US submarine

The US has replaced a gear stick-like control for a submarine periscope with Xbox-controllers on the USS Colorado, the latest Virginia-class attack submarine to be deployed by the US Navy. Utilising readily available tech reduces cost and training time.

<http://dgit.in/XBoxSub>



Video referees for World Cup 2018

After a general confirmation earlier in March, FIFA has finally officially approved the use of Video Assistant Referees, or VARs, in the 2018 FIFA World Cup. The tool will help referees with difficult calls during a game.

<http://dgit.in/FIFVAR>



NASA to use portable antennae

The design, from ATLAS Space Operations, involves four antennae, weighing approximately 10lb each. They can be set up and taken down within a short amount of time. Also, the antennae will only require internet and power to function.

<http://dgit.in/NASAPort>